

# Syllabus

MAT 5173 — Algebra I Fall 2026 · UT San Antonio

## Texts and Materials

---

### Primary text

- **Ash** — Ash, *Abstract Algebra: The Basic Graduate Year*, 2002

### Secondary reading

- **LiZh** — Li & Zhao, *Introduction to Abstract Algebra*, Les Ulis: EDP Sciences, 2022. ISBN 978-2-7598-2915-6. DOI: 10.1051/978-2-7598-2916-3. Gentler (undergraduate-level) discussion of many topics in Ash. (Primary text for MAT 4233's.)
- **CLO** — Cox, Little & O'Shea, *Ideals, Varieties, and Algorithms*, 5th ed., Springer, 2025. ISBN 978-3-031-91840-7. DOI: 10.1007/978-3-031-91841-4. Algebraic geometry text; supplements Ash Ch. 8.

### Supplementary reading

- **Shafarevich** — Shafarevich, *Basic Algebraic Geometry 1*, 3rd ed., Springer, 2013. ISBN 978-3-642-37955-0. DOI: 10.1007/978-3-642-37956-7
- **Rosebrock** — Rosebrock, *Visual Group Theory*, Springer, 2024. ISBN 978-3-662-69364-3. DOI: 10.1007/978-3-662-69365-0
- **Beardon** — Beardon, *Algebra and Geometry*, Cambridge University Press, 2005. ISBN 978-0-521-81362-4. DOI: 10.1017/CBO9780511800436

## Course Information

---

### Catalog Entry

MAT 5173 Algebra I

The opportunity for development of basic theory of algebraic structures. Areas of study may include monoids, semigroups, groups, isomorphism theorems, free groups, group extensions and group actions, Sylow theorems, group chains and composition series, nilpotent and solvable groups, cohomology of groups.

### Prerequisites

MAT 4233 or consent of instructor.

### Credit Hours

3

### Course Modality

Traditional in-person

### Class Meetings

---

Duration    Wed 19 Aug – Thu 3 Dec

---

|          |                       |
|----------|-----------------------|
| Campus   | Main Campus           |
| Location | MH 3.03.10            |
| Time     | Mon Wed 7:30PM–8:45PM |

---

## Learning Objectives

---

By the end of this course you should be able to:

- Define the notions of group, cyclic group, subgroup, normal subgroup, homomorphism, isomorphism, permutation group.
- Describe and analyze examples of groups, emphasizing groups of geometric transformations.
- Define group actions, emphasizing geometric actions.
- Define the notions of ring, subring, domain, field, ideal, homomorphism, isomorphism.
- Define rings of polynomials over a field, the notion of degree, and irreducible factors.
- Explore connections of the abstract theory of rings, polynomials and ideals with the geometry of algebraic varieties.
- Communicate concepts in writing and debate technical arguments orally.

## About the Instructor

---

Eduardo Dueñez, Associate Professor of Mathematics.

---

|               |                                                                         |
|---------------|-------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Department    | Mathematics                                                             |
| Office        | FLN 4.01.11                                                             |
| Student hours | Mon 5:30PM – 6:30PM & Tue 1:30PM – 2:30PM                               |
| Email         | <a href="mailto:eduardo.duenes@utsa.edu">eduardo.duenes@utsa.edu</a>    |
| Homepage      | <a href="https://supernumero.us/about">https://supernumero.us/about</a> |

---

Email is the preferred method of communication.

## Assessment and Grading

---

### Weight of course activities

---

| Component      | Weight |                                             |
|----------------|--------|---------------------------------------------|
| Q&A sessions   | 40%    | 4 sessions, 10% each; none dropped          |
| Problem sets   | 15%    | 4 sets, 3.75% each; graded for completeness |
| Midterm Exam 1 | 20%    | In class, Mon 5 Oct                         |
| Midterm Exam 2 | 25%    | Wed 2 Dec in class                          |

---

### Q&A sessions

Four class meetings throughout the semester (roughly every other Wednesday except when adjacent to an exam) will be *Q&A sessions* in which each student will be asked to explain and defend their solution to a homework problem

submitted as part of a written assignment. You will only be asked questions related to an assigned problem and about the solution you submitted.

Each Q&A session is scored 0–3:

- **3** Correct explanation to a correct solution, demonstrating full understanding of the concepts and all aspects of the solution submitted.
- **2** A completely correct solution submitted is explained to an incomplete degree; **Or**: an unfinished solution, with a thorough and articulate account of what you tried, explaining where and why you got stuck while demonstrating knowledge of the background and reading necessary to solve the problem.
- **1** Correct solution inadequately explained revealing little or no understanding; *or*: partial solution accompanied by an incomplete but partly correct oral explanation.
- **0** Nothing submitted; *or*: work submitted (even if fully correct) is backed by no cogent explanation nor knowledge of concepts involved.

**A correct answer you cannot explain is worth less than an explainable honest failure.**

**Note:** A low Q&A average caps the course grade, whatever the other components come to:

- a Q&A average **below 1.5** caps the course grade at **C**;
- a Q&A average **below 1.0** caps the course grade at **D**.

(An average below 1.0 is of course also below 1.5; in that case the ‘D’ cap is the one that applies.)

## Problem sets

Four sets, each with five or six theoretical problems. **Maximum six pages.**

Computational (SageMath) material is supplementary and entirely optional: it is never part of a problem set or a Q&A session, and it is not graded.

Each item will be scored *only* based on the **degree of completion** (not on correctness): **2** for a nominally complete solution, **1** for a clearly partial one, **0** for nothing submitted or for obvious filler with no substance.

*Note:* Any submission containing non-human-readable content, stray characters, or artifacts revealing non-proofread AI output scores 0 for that item.

## Use of Artificial Intelligence (AI)

**AI assistance is allowed in preparing work for submission**, as are any solution keys, collaboration, and internet sources. You are ultimately responsible for your submissions; any part of your work that has clearly not been proofread (e.g., includes non-human readable characters or LLM artifacts) automatically earns a zero grade. *Include one line noting what resources you used in your submission.*

This policy is by design, and it reflects how the course is graded: 85% of the grade comes from Q&A sessions and in-class exams where only what is truly understood and can be explained counts. Assignments submitted but not written/understood by you result in failing grades in Q&A sessions and exams. Use AI to learn faster —not to prepare and turn in papers you cannot defend, blocking you from passing exams as well.

All audiovisual (or audio only, or video only) recordings of lectures are explicitly forbidden; all uses of AI agents or apps to capture, process, or analyze any lecture contents are **strictly forbidden**. The only *limited* exceptions are *explicitly* allowed recordings per official memorandum of the office of Student Disability Services. Under no circumstances is any processing or analyzing of such recordings allowed. Any sharing of confidential course materials with individuals who are not enrolled students in the course is a violation of **FERPA privacy laws**.

## Exams

Both exams are traditional in-class (written and closed book). Exams are based **primarily on the assigned problem sets**—expect some context and phrasing to differ from the homework, plus a minority of other unseen problems. Memorizing solutions will not result in good exam grades; preparing by understanding the assigned problems will make the exams straightforward and earn high Q&A grades as well.

## Attendance and missed work

No extensions on problem sets. A *single* missed Q&A session in the semester may be made up during office hours within seven days (no documentation is required). *No Q&A scores are dropped.*

## Final grade ranges

| Grade | Range       | Grade | Range      |
|-------|-------------|-------|------------|
| A     | [90%, 100%] | A-    | [85%, 90%) |
| B+    | [80%, 85%)  | B     | [76%, 80%) |
| B-    | [72%, 76%)  | C+    | [69%, 72%) |
| C     | [65%, 69%)  | C-    | [60%, 65%) |
| D     | [50%, 60%)  | F     | [0%, 50%)  |

## Time Commitment Expectations

Expect an average of about **9 hours per week**, and no fewer than 7.

- Attend class meetings (**3 hours per week**)
- Reading the assigned textbook sections (**2–3 hours per week**)
- Problem sets (**2–3 hours per week**)
- Office hours and study group (**1 hours per week**)

## A Writing-Intensive Course

This is a **writing-intensive course**. Standard professional standards for technical writing (mathematical writing) apply. The style is *mathematical prose* written for a human reader. An otherwise “correct” argument presented as a disorganized or unintelligible pile of symbols is not a solution will be returned without grading and earn *no* credit. For detailed requirements and required reading refer to the **Writing Mathematics** page.

## Additional Course Information

Each student should be intimately familiar with the contents of any work submitted for grading. The instructor has the right to request adequate **verbal explanation** of methodology and content for any submitted work. Credit will not be awarded when such an explanation is requested but not satisfactorily provided.

## Course Schedule

| Date       | Topic                                                                                                |
|------------|------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------------|
| Wed 19 Aug | Lecture — Course launch; groups and subgroups                                                        |
| Mon 24 Aug | Lecture — Permutation groups; cyclic groups; the order of an element                                 |
| Wed 26 Aug | Lecture — Cosets, normal subgroups and homomorphisms                                                 |
| Mon 31 Aug | Lecture — The isomorphism theorems                                                                   |
| Wed 2 Sep  | Lecture — Direct products                                                                            |
| Wed 9 Sep  | <b>Q&amp;A (Due: Set 1)</b>                                                                          |
| Mon 14 Sep | Lecture — Rings: basic definitions and properties                                                    |
| Wed 16 Sep | Lecture — Ideals, homomorphisms and quotient rings; the isomorphism theorems for rings               |
| Mon 21 Sep | Lecture — Maximal and prime ideals                                                                   |
| Wed 23 Sep | Lecture — Polynomial rings; unique factorization                                                     |
| Mon 28 Sep | Lecture — Principal ideal domains and Euclidean domains; rings of fractions; irreducible polynomials |
| Wed 30 Sep | <b>Q&amp;A (Due: Set 2)</b>                                                                          |
| Mon 5 Oct  | <b>Exam</b> — Midterm Exam 1 — Sets 1 and 2                                                          |
| Wed 7 Oct  | Lecture — Field extensions; degree; simple extensions                                                |
| Wed 14 Oct | Lecture — Splitting fields; algebraic closures                                                       |
| Mon 19 Oct | Lecture — Separability; normal extensions; finite fields                                             |
| Wed 21 Oct | Lecture — Affine space and affine varieties                                                          |
| Mon 26 Oct | Lecture — $V(I)$ and $I(V)$ : algebra $\leftrightarrow$ geometry                                     |
| Wed 28 Oct | Lecture — The coordinate ring; the algebra-geometry dictionary; Hilbert's Nullstellensatz            |
| Mon 2 Nov  | <b>Q&amp;A (Due: Set 3)</b>                                                                          |
| Wed 4 Nov  | Lecture — The Hilbert basis theorem; Noetherian rings                                                |
| Mon 9 Nov  | Lecture — Plane curves: rational curves; nodes and cusps                                             |
| Wed 11 Nov | Lecture — Fixed fields and Galois groups                                                             |
| Mon 16 Nov | Lecture — The fundamental theorem of Galois theory                                                   |
| Wed 18 Nov | Lecture — Survey: the unsolvability of the quintic                                                   |
| Mon 23 Nov | <b>Q&amp;A (Due: Set 4)</b>                                                                          |
| Mon 30 Nov | <i>Review</i> — Review — the exam pool                                                               |
| Wed 2 Dec  | <b>Exam</b> — Midterm Exam 2 — Sets 3 and 4                                                          |

Readings for each meeting are on the [Weekly Schedule](#) (also available as a [printable PDF](#)).

## Department and University Policies

### Ombudsperson

The ombudsperson is an advocate who investigates complaints about a specific section or instructor and attempts to resolve them through mediation. Comments or complaints sent to this person will be brought to the attention of department leadership, who will follow up. If you have questions about the logistics of your class, please contact the instructor.

Contact Ilse Rosales Martinez at [ilse.rosalesmartinez@utsa.edu](mailto:ilse.rosalesmartinez@utsa.edu).

### Video and Audio Recording

As the instructor of this course, I may record meetings and lessons. You are expected to follow appropriate University policies and maintain the security of passwords used to access recorded lectures. Recordings may not be

published, reproduced, or shared with those not in the class. If the instructor or a UTSA office plans any other uses for the recordings, consent of the students identifiable in the recordings is required before such use unless an exception is allowed by law.

## Syllabus Changes

The syllabus is subject to change at the instructor's discretion. Any changes or corrections to the course materials, assignment dates, or other updates will be communicated to students ahead of time. You are responsible for checking Canvas for corrections or updates to the syllabus.

## Essential Student Information

- **Important:** Bookmark and visit the [Common Syllabus Information webpage](#) for resources about counseling services, transitory/minor medical issues, supplemental instruction, tutoring services, academic success coaching, sexual harassment and sexual misconduct, campus safety and emergency preparedness, and the Roadrunner Creed.
- For technical requirements, support, and resources, visit [Academic Innovation's Student Technical Support page](#).
- UT San Antonio provides reasonable accommodations to students via [Student Disability Services](#), or call (210) 458-4157.
- Your well-being is important. Support, including [24/7 mental health services](#), can be accessed from the [Well-being at UT San Antonio](#) site.
- [Student Assistance Services](#) offers confidential support and personalized guidance.
- The [Roadrunner Pantry](#) provides free access to groceries, toiletries, and other essentials.
- Students are responsible for ensuring their work is consistent with UTSA's standards for academic integrity. Review [Section 203 of the Student Code of Conduct](#).
- Visit [UT San Antonio Libraries and Museums](#) for journals, research tutorials, and your department's librarian.